FLORIDA

The Sunshine State



The Calusa people fished these waters for centuries, harvesting grouper from the shallow coral ledges that ran the length of the archipelago. They understood the rhythms of the tides and the seasons, and the sea provided reliably—grouper, snapper, mullet, and shellfish pulled fresh from some of the most productive waters in the Americas. When Spanish explorers arrived in the 1500s, they brought with them Citrus aurantifolia—the small, thin-skinned lime that would eventually seed itself so thoroughly into the rocky limestone soil of the Keys that future generations would simply call it the Key lime, as if the land itself had invented it.

By the late 1800s, waves of Bahamian immigrants—many of them skilled Black fishermen, spongers, and wreckers—had settled throughout the Keys, particularly around Key West and Islamorada. They brought with them a cooking tradition built on coconut, citrus, and whatever the sea offered that morning. Coconut rice, slow-simmered and fragrant, was a staple carried north from the islands and quietly woven into the fabric of Keys cooking. Their influence shaped what Florida food became in ways that history was slow to credit, but that anyone who ate at a Keys table could taste.

When Henry Flagler's Overseas Railroad reached Islamorada in 1908, it stitched the remote Keys to the mainland and carried wealthy Northern sportsmen southward, hungry for both the legendary fishing and the food that surrounded it. Grouper, thick-shouldered and white-fleshed, was the prize of the local waters. The Key limes growing wild in the hammocks had long since found their way into the cooking—their sharp, floral juice doing something remarkable to fresh fish, cutting the sweetness of the flesh and brightening everything it touched.

What emerged over generations was less a single invention than an inevitability—the natural result of a place defined by water, citrus, and the hands of many cultures. The Calusa knew the fish. The Spanish brought the lime. The Bahamians contributed the rice and the seasoning wisdom of island cooking. Florida simply set the table where all of it came together.

Now you can bring that same table to your own kitchen. The char of the grill, the bright snap of Key lime, the creamy pull of coconut rice—this dish doesn't just taste like Florida. It is Florida. Simple enough for a weeknight, and memorable enough to make anyone at your table close their eyes on the first bite.

KEY LIME GRILLED GROUPER AND COCONUT RICE

Long before Florida was a destination, the Keys were already a kitchen—where fresh grouper meets citrus, coconut, and sun.

Yield: 4 servings

INGREDIENTS

KEY LIME GRILLED GROUPER

- 4 grouper fillets (6–8 oz. each)
- ¼ cup Key lime juice (6–8 Key limes)
- 2 Tbsp olive oil
- 1 Tbsp melted butter
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 tsp honey or agave syrup
- ½ tsp paprika
- Salt and pepper, to taste

COCONUT RICE

- 1 cup jasmine rice
- 1 cup canned coconut milk
- ½ cup water
- 1 Tbsp sugar
- ¼ tsp salt
- 1–2 Tbsp shredded coconut, for garnish (optional)
- Fresh cilantro, for garnish (optional)
- Lime wedges, for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare the marinade*: In a small bowl, whisk together the Key lime juice, olive oil, melted butter, garlic, honey, paprika, salt and black pepper. If you like a zestier flavor, add lime zest from the Key limes.
2. *Marinate fish*: Place the grouper fillets in a shallow dish or resealable bag and pour marinade over the fish. Let marinate in refrigerator for 20–30 minutes. Avoid over-marinating as the lime juice can "cook" the fish.
3. *Rinse the rice*: Rinse the rice under cold water until the water runs clear.
4. *Cook rice*: Combine the rice, coconut milk, water, sugar, and salt in a medium saucepan and stir to mix. Heat on medium-high until boiling, stirring occasionally to prevent sticking.
5. *Simmer*: Once boiling, reduce heat to low, cover the saucepan with a lid, and let simmer for 15–20 minutes, or until all the liquid is absorbed and the rice is tender.
6. *Preheat grill*: Preheat the grill to 375–400°F (190–204°C). Lightly oil the grates to prevent sticking.
7. *Grill the grouper*: Remove the grouper from the marinade, letting the excess drip off. Grill for 3–4 minutes each side, depending on thickness, until fish is opaque and flakes easily.
8. *Finish the rice*: Remove from heat and fluff the rice with a fork.
9. *Serve*: Transfer to plates and garnish with shredded coconut, cilantro, and a squeeze of lime juice.

